



Marie Antoinette's diamond earrings

△ Marie Antoinette pictured wearing the earrings

Reigning as the queen of France alongside King Louis XVI from 1774 to 1792, Marie Antoinette was the most glamorous woman in Europe in the 18th century, setting trends that were slavishly followed by fashionable ladies of the royal courts. Her extravagance provided fuel for the satirical newspapers of the day, and her love of fine clothes and jewellery earned her the nickname “Madame Déficit”.

Among her indulgences were up to 300 dresses a year, countless pairs of perfumed gloves, and a hoard of sparkling jewellery. Some of it was made from paste (heavy flint glass) but much of it was real, including a favourite of the queen – a pair of diamond earrings with pear-shaped drops, one weighing 20.34 carats, the other weighing 14.25 carats. Thought to be a gift from Louis XVI, and commissioned from jewellers to the French court Boehmer and Bassenge, the earrings are believed to have passed down through the French royal family following Marie Antoinette's death by guillotine in 1793 during the French Revolution. They resurfaced some 60 years later as a wedding gift from Napoleon III to Empress Eugénie, who was fascinated by,

and modelled her style on, Marie Antoinette. After Eugénie was exiled to England in 1871, the earrings were sold to a Russian aristocrat, who in turn sold them to jeweller Pierre Cartier in 1928. In the same year, they were bought by American socialite Marjorie Merriweather Post, and in 1964 her daughter donated them to the Smithsonian Institution in the US, where they can still be seen in the Gem Gallery.



Portrait of Empress Eugénie, who received the earrings from Napoleon III as a wedding gift, and sold them after Napoleon's defeat in the Franco-Prussian War in 1871

Every woman wanted to imitate the queen. Everyone rushed to get the same jewellery

Madame **Campan**

First lady-in-waiting to Marie Antoinette

Key dates

1755–1964

